INDIA TODAY S2
STATE OF THE STATES
TAMIL NADU FIRST

This has helped Tamil Nadu earn the No.1 rank among all Indian states in apparel production and No.2 in textiles. Moreover, this sector provides employment to 35 per cent of the state's population. Tirupur is the biggest knitting cluster in the country and contributes to 90 per cent of the knitwear exports.

Agriculture continues to be the largest source of livelihood in the state. This sector has played a big role in reducing rural poverty over the years. Tamil Nadu is one of India's leading horticulture states, thanks to its diversified agro-climatic conditions suitable for a wide range of horticulture crops. It is planning to set up a major agro-industrial corridor, including in the infrastructure deficit Cauvery delta districts.

The reason behind Tamil Nadu's exceptional progress in all these sectors is its strong focus on literacy. With 82.9 per cent literacy, the state has done exceptionally well in the field of education. It has the highest number of deemed universities and the highest share (18 per cent) of technical institutions in India. It is home to 37 colleges ranked in the top 100 in the country.

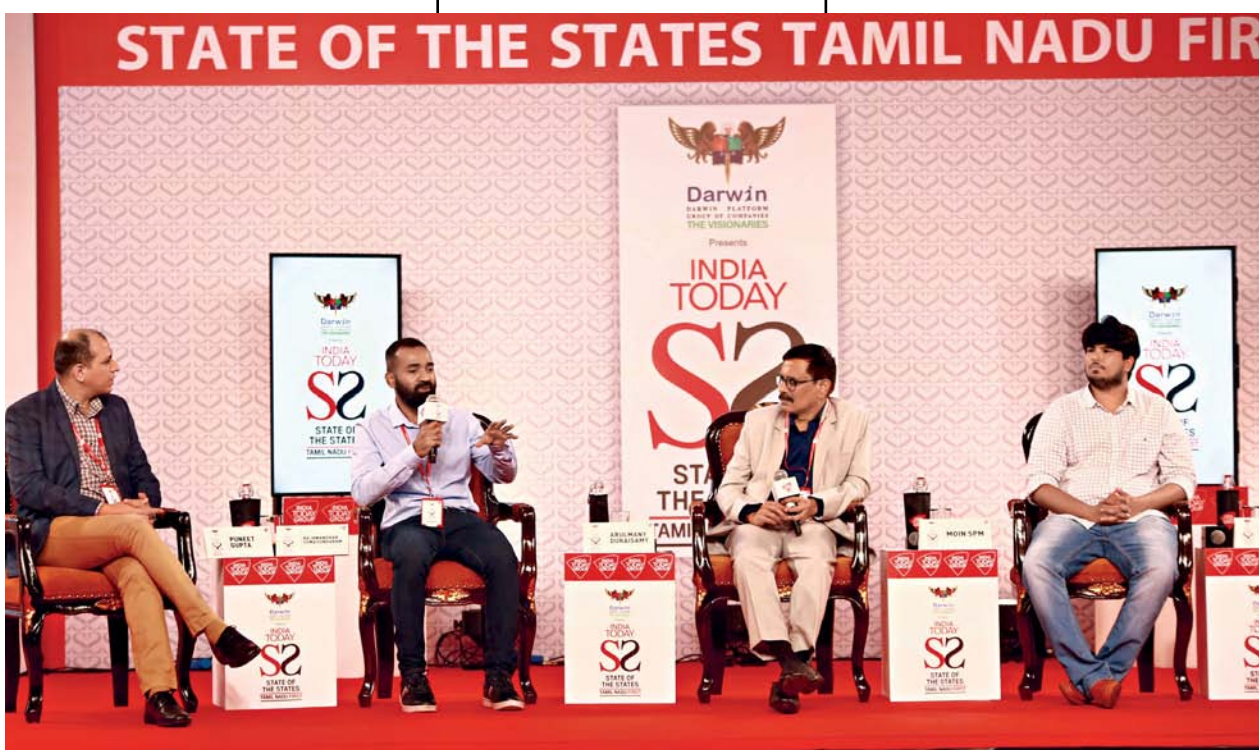
Despite these impressive numbers, there are areas of concern. The 15th Finance Commission report points out that Tamil Nadu's revenue to fiscal deficit ratio has been approaching 50 per cent in recent years. This implies that most borrowings are being used to finance its revenue deficit, which implies less money for capital expenditure. Another concern is that rural indebtedness now impacts 61 per cent of farm households in the state, which is much higher than the national average of 47 per cent. The power and transport sector are in need of urgent reforms as well.

The Tamil Nadu Conclave saw experts from across fields come together to offer prescriptions for different sectors for the state to grow at an even faster pace. ■

▼ START-UP SAGA: CAN CHENNAI BE THE NEXT BENGALURU FOR START-UPS?

TAKEAWAYS

1. Make matters of space and space technology accessible to the common man.
2. Value and recognise hardware start-ups with state helping provide infrastructure.
3. Treat start-ups as customers and enable them fulfil compliance issues.
4. Create a mini start-up city to attract more players.
5. Provide continuity with a 15-year long term perspective in the newly introduced FinTech policy.
6. Give priority to service-based sectors.



(from left) **Puneet Gupta,** *Co- founder, Kaleidofin;* **Rajamanohar Somasundaram,** *CEO & Co-Founder, Aquaconnect;* **Arulmany Duraisamy,** *MD & CEO, Veritas Finance;* **Moin S.P.M.,** *Co-founder & COO, Agnikul*